

you can turn down loan offers. There's no sense going into debt for something you could pay for interest free.)

I was furious to learn that tuition numbers could fluctuate. I can't imagine the cool-as-hell teen who lights up a cigar and slides the envelope back across the table to NYU's admissions department with a chilly, "No dice." Ivey said unless something massively bad happens, a school isn't going to take away an acceptance once it's been given. So why not negotiate the price?

Choosing a school makes you a consumer paying for a product (education); the cost shouldn't be a mystery or a burden. What can we do? These are Peeler's thoughts:

1. Read your award letter carefully, and look up anything you don't understand. Note what's a grant (aka free money) and what's a loan (which you'll pay to borrow).
2. Understand interest. Your interest rate tells you how much you'll pay each year to borrow the money you're being loaned. Financial aid award letters don't typically show interest rates. (Tricky!)
3. Think ahead when choosing a major. Peeler said a lot of people pick a course of study without looking at the top jobs and starting salaries. It might be a downer to look at the annual salary of say a book editor or journalist (low, guys; it's low), but it might influence your choice.

Ivey said it doesn't help that college admissions are purposely confusing when it comes to finances. Need-blind admission doesn't mean that once accepted, the school will fill in that need. If you're on the margins for admission, your ability to pay tuition may factor in to whether a school can afford to help you attend. (Ivey said rejection is more humane than getting students' hopes up and then not providing the funds for them to attend.) I don't know what's worse: not getting in, getting in and not being able to afford it, or getting in and spending the rest of your life bogged down in debt. All three are common problems.